

BACK TO THE MAINSTREAM
A group of Naxals who surrendered along with their arms at Sukma, Mar. 2; (below) Sodhi Muiya and his wife Vineeta, who were associated with the movement from 2006 to 2021



members between Rs 1 lakh and Rs 2 lakh, area committee members Rs 5 lakh, and divisional committee members Rs 8 lakh. Surrendering weapons fetches additional rewards—an AK-series rifle, for instance, brings an extra Rs 4 lakh. While serious criminal charges remain, minor offences may be resolved through plea bargaining.

The intensification of anti-Naxal operations since 2024 has not only seen a spike in the number of rebels killed but also those who have surrendered. In 2023, 398 Naxals had surrendered in Bastar, the movement's epicentre in recent years. This number doubled to 800 in 2024, a year that also saw 217 Naxals killed in the region—the highest in the state's history and a huge uptick from just 20 the previous year.

Internal strife among the Naxals has further driven surrenders. For instance, Sodhi Muiya and his wife Vineeta (see picture above), associated with the movement from 2006 to 2021, defected after he was accused of being a police informer. Fearing execution, he sought help from a local political leader's relative to facilitate his surrender. His wife followed suit. Muiya, formerly an area committee secretary, was rewarded Rs 8 lakh and a job in the office of the Sukma superintendent of police (SP), while Vineeta was appointed as a Gopniya Sainik (secret soldier). "My only regret is that I still can't return to my village for fear of retribution," says Muiya.

BY PROVIDING NAXAL CADRES A PEACEFUL EXIT, THE SURRENDER POLICY HAS HELPED REDUCE INSURGENT NUMBERS AND DISRUPTED THE LEADERSHIP STRUCTURE

Many surrendered Naxals now serve in the District Reserve Guard (DRG), a force known for its effectiveness against insurgency in Chhattisgarh. Comprised of local recruits, the DRG benefits from deep familiarity with the terrain, language and Naxal tactics. Recruits join as assistant constables, constables or Gopniya Sainiks, with relaxed physical and educational criteria to encourage local enlistment. "Nobody knows the terrain like we do. We have grown up facing adversities and it shows when we enter the battle," says Inderjeet Kumar, a DRG constable in Sukma.

Currently, the DRG has approximately 3,600 personnel. It also includes a women's unit, the Danteshwari Fighters, currently numbering around 100 personnel. Another locally recruited force, the Bastar Fighters, was introduced in 2021, comprising 2,100 personnel across seven districts. Both forces played a crucial role in 2024's record-breaking counter-insurgency successes. According to Sukma SP Kiran Chavan, surrenders remain a key operational strategy. "Successful surrenders provide intelligence on active cadres, sow discontent among Maoists, and encourage more rebels to defect," he says. It's not for nothing that the DRG, with surrendered rebels accounting for 18 per cent of its strength, is called the tip of the spear. ■